

TRUST AND SAFETY AUDIT: MID-POINT REPORT DOCUMENT

New York University Tandon School of Engineering
Computer Science and Engineering
Spring 2026

Instructor:	Prof. Rosanna Bellini	Time:	Monday 11.00 AM – 1.30 PM
Email:	bellini@nyu.edu	Place:	2 MetroTech Center, Room 812
Office Hours:	Tue 12:30 – 1:30PM*	Office:	370 Jay Street, Office 1056

*Please email me to set up an appointment at any other time.

Overview

As you'll know, over the course of the Fall semester, you are working in **groups of 2–3 people** (or solo) to conduct original research in the area of Trust and Safety. This Midpoint Check-In Document serves as an stop-gap progress report for your Trust & Safety Audit (the Group Project). This document should demonstrate your understanding of your harm type, explain your methodological planning, and show the progress made toward your final deliverables at the end of the semester. It also acts as the basis for our optional midpoint meeting and for you to receive targeted feedback on your research direction, feasibility, and next steps. The more work you do ahead of this time, the more Rosie can help you.

You should use either the **USENIX Security Overleaf template** ([Overleaf v.2023](#)) or the **Word template** ([Word v.2022](#)) for this document. This is the same template as the Intention Document; please feel free to continue using the same document. [Purple writing like this is used as placeholders to provide an example.](#) **Each team member needs to upload a copy of the final document into BrightSpace.** Your *Mid-Semester Report Document* must include the following three sections (at a minimum) and be **around five pages**. For reference, your final report (due at the end of the semester) will be **ten** pages:

Introduction

The introduction should set the stage for your project and communicate **why** it matters. Readers of your work should understand your research motivation within a few paragraphs. Strong introductions move from a specific harm to its systemic implications, making the reader care about both the existence of the harm and what we should do about it. What to include in the prose:

- **Problem Statement:** Clearly describe the specific harm, vulnerability, or trust & safety concern your project addresses. You can use screenshots, URLs or mainstream media articles to help highlight this point. For example: [coordinated harassment targeting creators, safety misfeatures in account recovery workflows, or how moderation affects small-business sellers.](#)
- **Motivation and Significance:** Explain why this issue is important in the broader landscape of trust and safety; it's not enough to say that there's an issue, see if you can get people to care about why its an issue in the first place. Consider answering such questions such as: a) What specific user group(s) are most affected? b) How does this problem intersect with security, privacy, or wellbeing?, c) Why is this harm understudied, misunderstood, or technically challenging to mitigate?, and d) What is at stake if we do not examine this problem in trust and safety?
- **Scope and Project:** Tightly define the boundaries of your study. By this, you should clarify what you are measuring, designing, or evaluating. In equal measure, you should clearly state what is out of scope (i.e., beyond your capabilities or not possible in the time frame). For example: [“We focus on user-to-user harassment reports on mid-sized platforms”](#) or [“Our prototype targets recovery from financial control abuse, not detection.”](#)

- **Project Outcomes:** End with a short sneakpeak of what you aim to contribute (e.g., a measurement framework, prototype, typology, or set of policy recommendations).

Related Work

The Related Work section positions your project within the existing scholarly and industry landscape; some of which we have covered in the lectures. It should demonstrate your awareness of what has been done already by existing scholars, and where your work contributes something new. Don't get too caught up on introducing something completely new (as this can be hard), but explain how your approach might not have been considered by other people before. Good related work sections are selective, analytical, and integrative; not just summaries of prior papers. What to include:

- **Core Sources:** Cite at least 3–5 relevant (academic or gray literature) works, ideally mixing peer-reviewed papers, industry reports, or credible white papers (e.g., from platforms, non-governmental organizations, or research institutes). This is exploring if you've done your reading beforehand and have some sensitivity to who is already conducting research in this area. For each source, briefly explain what it contributes (is a method you'd like to copy, empirical data you want to build on?) and how it informs the direction of your own project. For example (from our first lecture together): *“Thomas et al. (2021) categorize hate and harassment typologies, but our project intends to apply this framework to understand scams on moderated livestream platforms”*
- **Identify Gaps:** To identify a ‘gap’, you should state how your project builds upon, extends, or contradicts others who have done work in this space. For instance, you might be testing an assumption (e.g., how safe are child safety features on Meta?), or highlighting that there are gaps in existing datasets in relation to hate and harassment. See if you can bridge this approach with a short paragraph which connects this literature to the methods you've chosen to use. For example: *“These studies emphasize individual harms, but our project focuses on relational ones between families.”*

Research Plan & Current Status

This is the most substantial (i.e., longest) section and should include both what has been done already and what lies ahead for your group (or yourself if doing this solo). Strong plans are realistic, specific, and self-reflective. This can mean acknowledging both what has gone well so far, and where guidance is needed. If you've ran into some challenges, feel free to explain how you have navigated them. What to include:

- **Research Questions or Objectives:** Restate 2–3 guiding research questions or goals that structure your work. These help to anchor you to what you are trying to answer by the time you present and hand-in your report in December. For example, questions might look like the following: *How do users recognize and respond to algorithmic harassment?* or *How can an interface redesign improve user comprehension of recovery options after they have been compromised?*
- **Methodological Approach:** Describe your planned or current methods, namely, how you are going to approach data collection (e.g., are you using primary or secondary data), prototype design, implement an audit study of specific platform features, or policy review. Try to be as specific as possible, such as including sample characteristics, how you are going to use specific tooling to explore your problem space, or the platforms you have chosen to study. If your methods have changed between now and the Intention Document, state a justification as for why; it's okay to change your mind or approach on things!
- **Progress to Date:** It is important that you summarize your specific accomplishments so far, ideally with proof that you've completed them. If you are making a prototype, this could be a link to your GitHub Repo, or some early survey design, and data collection.

- ***Next Steps:*** Outline what remains (e.g., further recruitment, data analysis, visualization, or report drafting). Importantly, this will also include how you have identified any ethical, technical, or logistical barriers and describe how you plan to address them. Try to keep these as realistic as possible.

Marking Rubric

Criterion	Excellent	Proficient	Developing	Limited/Unfinished	Marks
Clarity, Structure, and Presentation	Writing is polished, concise, and logically organized. All sections complete and formatted correctly. Free of grammar or style errors.	Mostly clear and organized; minor issues in flow or formatting; minor typos.	Writing occasionally unclear or disjointed; inconsistent formatting or missing section headers.	Unclear or incomplete; poor organization or significant grammar/formatting issues.	20
Relevance to T&S Themes	Strong and specific links to multiple course themes; demonstrates deep understanding of T&S content.	Clear connection to at least one course theme or reading.	Mentions course concepts but connection is vague or underdeveloped.	Lacks any meaningful link to course content or T&S broadly.	10
Project Summary	Interesting and clearly scoped problem; strong motivation and relevance; identifies stakeholders (e.g., platforms) and harms precisely.	Clear problem and rationale; some gaps in scope or stakeholder framing.	Problem too broad, generic, or weakly motivated; unclear target audience or harms.	Problem missing or unrelated to T&S context.	20
Feasibility & Methodological Soundness	Methods, data sources, and timeline are detailed, realistic, and coherent; clearly achievable within the semester.	Sound plan with minor feasibility or methodological issues.	Plan lacks specificity or feasibility; unclear data access or methodological rigor.	Plan implausible, incoherent, or absent.	20
Anticipated Risks or Challenges	Identifies multiple credible risks (ethical, technical, practical) and offers thoughtful mitigation strategies.	Identifies one or more realistic risks and partial mitigation plan.	Mentions general risks with little depth or detail.	No discussion of challenges or mitigation.	20
Expected Outcomes	Expected outcomes are specific, measurable, and align with methods and course goals.	Outcomes described clearly but somewhat generic or lacking detail.	Outcomes vague or not directly connected to the plan.	Outcomes missing or unrealistic.	10

Table 1: Marking Rubric for Intention Document, Scored out of 100